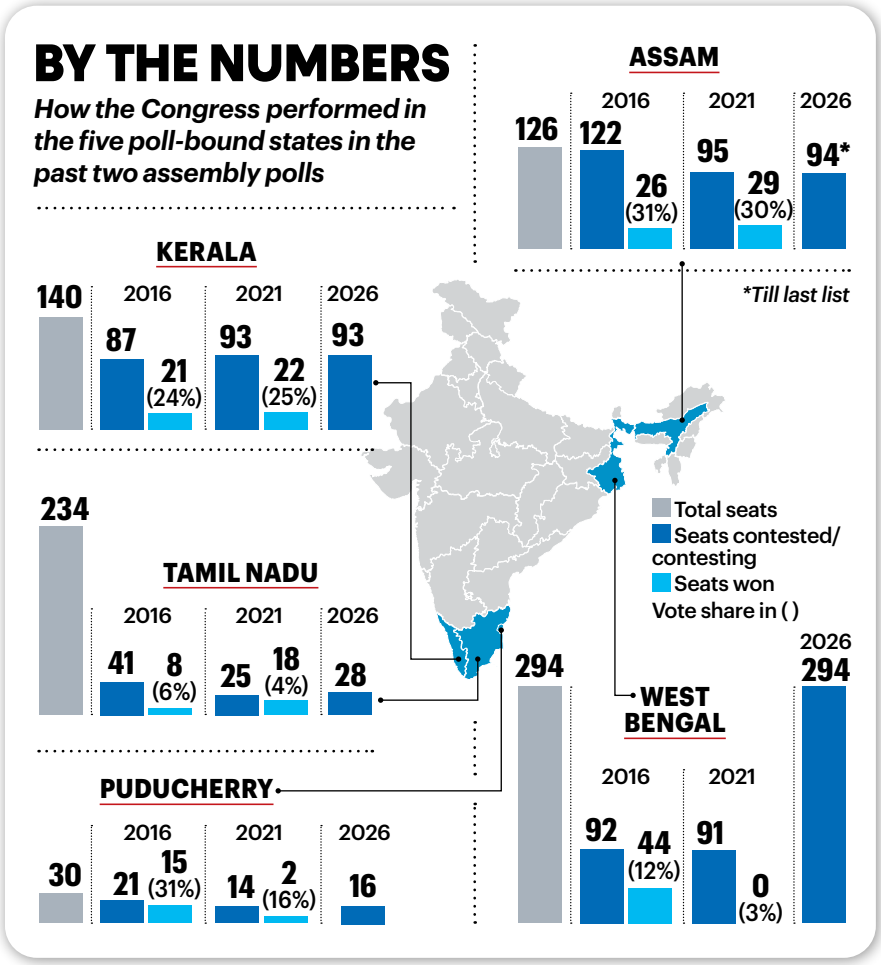


fury in the DMK over what it saw as the Congress exploring an alternative alliance. The DMK responded with a 'take it or leave it' deadline of March 3, backed by pointed data: the Congress won only 5 of 63 seats when it last contested independently in 2011, and its standalone vote share in the 2014 Lok Sabha was a mere 4.5 per cent.

The alliance was ultimately rescued by Sonia Gandhi's direct intervention. She dispatched P. Chidambaram as her personal envoy to meet M.K. Stalin, the DMK chief and CM. The March 4 deal—28 seats plus one Rajya Sabha berth—reflected a pragmatic compromise, though it fell far short of the party's ambitions.

The Congress's electoral prospects in Tamil Nadu are almost entirely a function of the DMK's performance. In 2021, the party won 18 of 25 allocated seats, a 72 per cent strike rate powered entirely by the DMK's organisational machinery and vote transfer. If the DMK support base holds, the Congress should comfortably win a majority of its 28 seats. If anti-incumbency bites, or TVK emerges as a serious third force, even the alliance's overall seat count could wobble.

WEST BENGAL

The Congress's decision to contest all 294 seats independently in West Bengal is perhaps the most audacious of its 2026 strategies. The 2021 Congress-Left alliance produced a total wipeout. The party did not win a single seat and its vote share was a catastrophic 2.94 per cent. This time, the ruling Trinamool Congress (TMC) showed no interest in seat-sharing, with national general secretary Abhishek Banerjee suggesting the Congress should 'unilaterally support' the TMC.

Adhir Ranjan Chowdhury, the former five-term Baharampur MP who lost his Lok Sabha seat to TMC in 2024, is expected to contest from the Baharampur constituency, his first state-level contest since 1996. At 70, he remains the party's most recognisable face in Bengal, particularly in the Murshidabad-Malda belt where the Congress retains residual organisational strength. State president Subhankar Sarkar has restructured the party organisation, expanding district units from 28 to 33 and constituting formal political affairs and election committees. But as of March 21, the Congress had still not released its candidate list, the last major party to do so.

The four-cornered fight dynamics (TMC vs BJP vs Congress vs Left) create a scenario where the Congress's presence primarily affects the margins. The party won 21 seats going solo in 2006, a distant high-water mark it hopes to eventually approach again. For now, even winning a handful of seats in Murshidabad, Malda and select pockets of North Bengal would be considered a meaningful step back from oblivion.

PUDUCHERRY

The most immediate crisis unfolded in this small Union territory, where a seat-sharing agreement with the DMK was finalised only on the last day of nominations, March 23. Under the deal, the Congress will contest 16 seats and the DMK 14 of the 30. In 2021, the DMK won six seats to the Congress's two. But the Congress is banking on its 2024 Lok Sabha performance, leading in 28 of 30 assembly segments; converting that momentum into assembly victories will require alliance chemistry to work on the ground. The delay in seat-sharing has already affected the preparations of several candidates and caused heartburn among those denied party tickets. In constituencies where victory margins are often just a few hundred votes, such ruptures could hand an advantage to the incumbent.

Across all five battlegrounds, a clear pattern stands out: the Congress's national brand and its ability to frame issues are far stronger than its organisational capacity on the ground. As a result, it enters 2026 as a party fighting for relevance state by state. ■